

11.2 Cataloguing Optical Media

As they say, first there was the Gramophone... The natural 'evolution' that audio playback formats have seen has led to the birth of the Audio CD. The Audio CD is basically the great-great grandson of those good ol' vinyl records. When vinyl was the standard, music wasn't recorded on records as 'data files'. Grooves were made on the records that were the analog signals that a Gramophone's needle picked up and amplified. Essentially, the case was similar when the audio CD was developed. Except here, the signals were digital, and the needle was replaced by a laser. Music wasn't stored on an Audio CD as data files. So apart from the inlay that was provided with the disc, there was no other digital identity that the songs had.

This meant that when you ripped the songs on to your computer they were given names like Track 01-76432908.mp3. So what was needed was another source from where the information about the songs on the CD could be accessed.

11.2.1 CDDB

CDDB stands for Compact Disc DataBase. When you play a Compact Disc in your computer, the media player that plays the songs accesses this database to get information about the songs on the disc. But how does the database know what CD you're playing? What happens is that an identification of the CD is created on the basis of the length (time) of the songs, and their order on the disc. This is then used to access information about the whole CD, or, in case of a CD whose 'identity' is yet new, to submit such information.

CDDB used to be a free database, but the project was sold (to a company called Gracenote) and the terms of the license were changed. This basically meant that developers needed to pay for the use of the database. Also, since the database was accessed on the basis of track lengths and their order, the database could not deliver information about compilation discs.